

BRAVE WARRIOR

Werner Voss, killed in 1917, was described by British ace James McCudden as "the bravest German airman whom it has been my privilege to see."



The ruthlessness of air combat was never better exemplified than by one of the very few recorded meetings of two aces in single combat. On November 23, 1916, British ace Major Lanoe Hawker, found himself isolated from his formation and targeted by the Red Baron, Manfred von Richthofen. The German was flying an Albatros D.I, Hawker a markedly inferior pusher D.H.2. The two machines, in Richthofen's words, "circled round and round like madmen." Hawker performed small miracles of agility, side-slipping his aircraft downward each time the German was about to capture him in his sights. But, inevitably, he eventually ran out of height. Down to treetop level and over enemy lines, Hawker desperately headed for home, zigzagging all the time. But Richthofen's machine was faster. Unable to shake him off, Hawker made a last attempt to turn and face his pursuer, but Richthofen opened fire as the Englishman banked and shot him through the head. Recounted in Richthofen's memoirs, this story hardly conforms to the chivalric stereotype. In effect, Richthofen ruthlessly hunted down a pilot who, for all his courage and skill, had no chance because his machine was inferior. It reads more like an assassination than a duel.

Mental torture

Whether aces or not, fighter pilots were subjected to unbearable strain at peak periods of the war. When men were flying three or four missions a day, seeing friends and colleagues dying before their eyes, often in the most gruesome fashion, they would pray for the relief of a "dud" day, when weather conditions made flying impossible. If losses were high, there would be a sharp rise in the number of pilots aborting missions, alleging

that their magazines had jammed or their engine was playing up. Pilots suffered from repeated nightmares, began to behave oddly, and sometimes lost their nerve completely.

In this context it is perhaps just possible to understand the mentality of British commanders who opposed the development of suitable parachutes for pilots because it might encourage them to jump out unnecessarily – in effect deserting in the face of the enemy. Yet the lack of parachutes contributed to the worst moments of the air war. A pilot might spiral down for minutes, out of control but uninjured, with nothing to do but wait to hit the ground. Or, worse, be trapped in a burning aircraft with no better options than jumping to his death or blowing his brains out with a revolver.

The best fighter pilots were far from immune to such pressures of combat flying. Before they died – and most of them did die – many of the aces were harrowed men, flying too many missions and living on the edge of their nerves. Some deliberately drove themselves beyond the

"Fight on and fly on to the last drop of blood and the last drop of fuel, to the last beat of the heart."

MANFRED VON RICHTHOFEN

DRINKING A TOAST TO HIS FELLOW PILOTS

limit. Guynemer, for example, feared that if he withdrew from combat, people would say it was because he had "won all the awards." Thus he died flying while patently unfit, physically ill, and racked by paranoia and insomnia.

A few aces died what could be called a hero's death. One such ace was German Werner Voss. On September 23, 1917, flying a Fokker triplane, Voss was bounced by a flight of S.E.5s led by James McCudden. As the S.E.5s dived down on his tail, Voss spun his aircraft to face them. McCudden wrote: "By now the German triplane was in the middle of our

formation, and its handling was wonderful to behold. The pilot seemed to be firing at all of us simultaneously, and although I got behind him a second time, I could hardly stay there for a second. His movements were so quick and uncertain that none of us could hold him in sight..." Two British machines were forced to withdraw, shot up by Voss' bullets, but then the German's luck ran out. One pilot, Arthur Rhys Davids, latched on to his tail and raked the triplane with repeated bursts of fire. McCudden saw Voss' aircraft "hit the ground and disappear into a thousand fragments... it literally went to a powder."

Inglorious deaths

Such a death was rare indeed. McCudden himself died in a mundane flying accident when returning from a spell in Britain to take command of a squadron in France. Guynemer simply vanished on a mission – no trace of him or his aircraft was ever found. Boelcke's funeral oration declared that there could be for him "no more beautiful way to end his life than flying for the fatherland," rhetoric that contrasted sadly with the manner of his death as victim of a collision with one of his own men.

But however much the reality of their mostly brief, brutal, nerve-racked lives might contrast with a romantic view of air war, the legend of the aces as "knights of the air" proved durable and an inspiration to a future generation of fliers. Charles Lindbergh, famed for the first solo, nonstop Atlantic crossing, recalled how, as a child during the war, he had "searched newspapers for reports of aerial combats – articles about Fonck, Mannock, Bishop, von Richthofen, and Rickenbacker," who were to him the modern equivalent of "King Arthur's knights in childhood stories." This myth was the aces' legacy.

TOP ALLIED ACE

With 75 victories to his name, French pilot René Fonck was the top Allied ace of the war. He twice shot down six German aircraft in a single day. A boastful individual, Fonck never won the popular affection granted to his compatriots Nungesser and Guynemer.

